The most important early theorists are ***Gaudapada*** (450–500 CE), ***Mandana Mishra*** (650–700 CE) and ***Shankara*** (c. 700 CE). *Sureshvara* probably belongs to the generation after ***Shankara*** and his major works are the *Naishkarmyasiddhi* and an exposition of ***Shankara***'s commentary on the *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad*.

Other important thinkers are ***Padmapada***, ***Prakashatman***, and *Vimuktatman*.

See ***Adhyasa***; ***Bhava-rupa-avidya***; ***Neti Neti***

Further reading: Gerow 1990; Halbfass 1995; Hiriyanna 1993; Potter 1981; Ram-Prasad 2002

Ahamkara (egoism and will): according to the ***Samkhya*** description of the world, which is accepted by ***Vedanta***, this is one of the constituents of human personality closely associated with the sense faculties and intellect. It usually means the sort of selfishness that results from identifying the soul (***atman***) with one's embodied life.

Further reading: Rocher 1988

Ahimsa (lack of desire to harm): this is a central idea in Indian religious culture. The *Laws of Manu*, which describes the social and religious duties obligations (***dharma***) to be performed by higher-caste Hindus concerned with preserving spiritual purity in a world permeated by polluting forces, states that ***ahimsa*** is a duty for Brahmins. The *Yoga-Sutra* (2.30) stipulates that ***ahimsa*** is one of the five forms of self-restraint (*yama*) to be exercised by practitioners of ***Yoga***. Avoiding taking life is one of the five basic precepts undertaken by all Buddhists. Non-violence was promoted as an ideal by the Emperor *Ashoka* (272–232 BCE), a convert to Buddhism, who conquered and ruled much of the Indian sub-continent. It is a fundamental ethical